

Charting the free churches

The Baptist, the Methodist, the Pentecostal, and the non-denominational believer, measured by the same nine rows part one measures the historic communions by.

Where the older communions are asked to set down what the whole Church never received, the free churches are asked to pick up what the whole Church always did. Same rows, opposite motion.

The charting papers, part two of three.

Back to part one: the historic communions · Continue to part three: the fifty objections.

Thus saith the LORD, “Stand ye in the ways, and see, and ask for the old paths, where is the good way, and walk therein, and ye shall find rest for your souls. But they said, We will not walk therein.” (Jeremiah 6:16)

Catholic means according to the whole, and catholicity is the faith the whole Church received in her first thousand years, the Scriptures, the Creed, the councils, the sacraments, the ordered ministry, and the morals of the Fathers, held everywhere, always, and by all. The front page states the whole case, and part one of these charting papers charts the ancient communions. This page charts the free churches by the same nine rows, and it stands on its own for the reader who arrived here first.

Half of America worships in a church younger than the automobile. What follows is a journey backward, from the strip mall to the altar of the first millennium: the family tree of the divisions, the verses quoted against creeds and priests read whole, the proof that the first churches were not low churches, the men the free churches love, Wesley, Edwards, Tozer, Seymour, every one of them reaching backward, the charts that measure each church from its own papers, the rapture and the gifts of the Spirit weighed, and then everything catholicity asks of each church by name, as part one asks it of Rome and the Orthodox. The historic communions were asked to set things down. The free churches of this page are asked the inverse, a picking up.

The free churches rest on a historical claim, that theirs is the primitive shape, church as the apostles left it before catholic accretion.

Produce a first-century free congregation in the record, and Part I falls. Produce the rapture taught before 1830, and the weighing of the system falls. Produce the council that dogmatized the ceasing of the gifts, and the gifts section falls.

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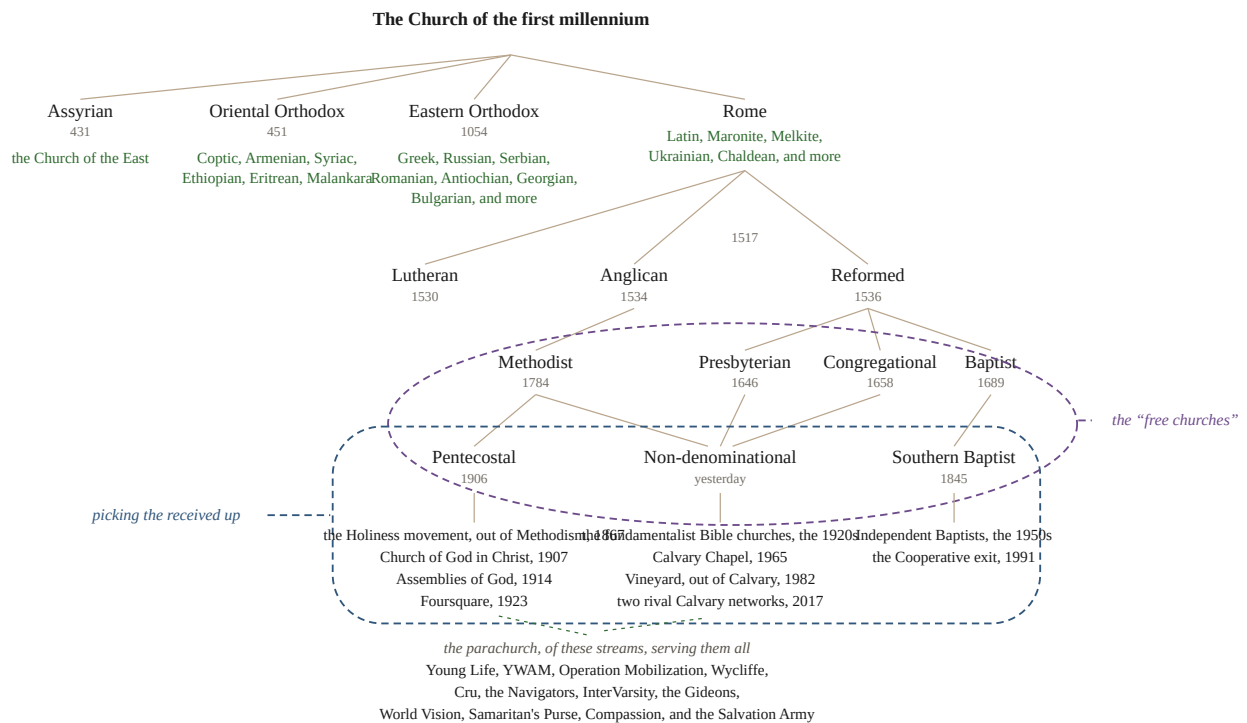
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The big picture

Out of the undivided Church came the divisions, first the eastern divisions of 431 and 451, then East and West in 1054, then the West's own children, each generation dividing faster than the last. The older communions, Rome and the Orthodox above all, carry things the whole Church never received, definitions bound by one part alone, and for them reunion means setting those down, the first motion, which part one charts. The purple ring marks the free churches themselves, and the older of them, Methodist to Baptist, stand in both motions, confessions of their own to hold as patrimony and rows of the inheritance to take back up. And the churches inside the blue border, the youngest, this page's main subject, carry almost nothing bound at all, and for them reunion means the second motion whole, picking up what the whole Church always carried, the creed, the Supper, the ministry, the inheritance thinned by the generations of division. The rest of this page is about the second motion, and the churches being asked to make it.



Each generation younger, smaller, and more alone. This page is about the youngest churches. Every solid brown line is a break of communion. The green names are sister churches in one communion, not divisions. The dashed green line is service, not schism. The purple ring is the free churches. The blue border is the youngest of them, asked to pick the received up. The setting down asked of the older communions is part one's work.

Most of the brown lines came with mutual sentences of hell attached. By the common counts, some 1.4 billion Roman Catholics, 300 million Orthodox of the East and the Orient, and 900 million heirs of the Reformation live today at the ends of those lines, the anathemas mostly still on the books.

This page is written for the Baptist, the Methodist, the Pentecostal, the non-denominational believer, and for the reader raised in those pews who wandered high-churchward and wants to know what this site says about home. And one line runs under everything here: the difference between the free churches and the first millennium is not in fervor but in shape.

Part I. The claim, and the record

The verses, read whole

The faith once delivered unto the saints (Jude 3). The favorite text against creeds is the strongest creedal text in the Bible. A faith once delivered is a fixed content, definite enough to contend for, which is precisely and only what a creed claims to be, the delivered thing written down so it can be guarded. Paul does exactly that: I delivered unto you first of all that which I also received, how that Christ died for our sins according to the scriptures, and that he was buried, and that he rose again the third day (1 Corinthians 15:3 to 5), a creed quoted inside the New Testament itself.

Hold to the traditions (2 Thessalonians 2:15). Paul commands the church to stand fast and hold the traditions they were taught, whether by word or by epistle, so the apostle binds unwritten teaching alongside the written in a single breath. The word is paradosis, the handing over, the same act Paul names for the Supper and for the resurrection formula, and the verse the refuser of tradition must explain is the one where tradition is commanded.

Believe and be baptized (Mark 16:16, Acts 2:38). Granted entirely. Then ask what baptism was. In the ancient rite the candidate was questioned in the water, article by article, do you believe in God the Father almighty, and answered credo three times going under. The creed is not an addition to believe-and-be-baptized. The creed is what believing said out loud at the moment of baptism, and it grew from the baptismal rite before any council polished it. The church that says just believe and be baptized is quoting the very rite that carried the creed, and Cyril's lectures to the candidates are the creed taught as baptismal preparation, on this site, in full.

A royal priesthood (1 Peter 2:9). Granted at full strength, for it is first-millennium doctrine and the Fathers preached it. But Peter is quoting Exodus 19:6, spoken to an Israel that had, in the same book, an ordained priesthood at God's own command. The royal priesthood of the whole people and an ordered ministry within it are not rivals but the original package, and the first millennium held both without strain. The verse abolishes nothing it coexisted with at Sinai.

And the New Testament keeps the same package. Let not many of you become teachers, my brethren, for you know that we who teach shall be judged with greater strictness (James 3:1 RSV), and the letters to Timothy and Titus spell out the qualifications of an office not every believer holds. Whatever the royal priesthood is, it does not nullify the presbyters and the bishop, however that old question is finally sorted. This is the same balance the whole Church always kept, the *sensus fidelium*, the instinct of the whole baptized people, weighing beside the councils and the Fathers and never instead of them. The whole people bears witness. The ordered ministry teaches, and is judged more strictly for it.

Call no man your father upon the earth (Matthew 23:9). Grant the target completely, for the Lord was striking the honor-hunger of the rabbis, the love of titles and the best seats. But read the whole saying, for the same breath forbids being called teacher and instructor, titles every free church prints in its bulletin without a tremor. And Paul, who knew the saying if anyone did, wrote to the Corinthians that in Christ Jesus I became your father through the gospel. Either the apostle broke the command, or the command forbids a vanity and not a vocabulary. The verse polices the heart's appetite for honor. It does not abolish the relation the apostle claimed in writing.

Where two or three are gathered (Matthew 18:20). Read the sentence before it. The context is the church's discipline, tell it to the church, whatsoever ye shall bind on earth shall be bound in heaven. The verse is about the assembled church's judicial authority, the least congregationalist verse in the Gospels wearing a congregationalist costume.

The council of Jerusalem (Acts 15). The first doctrinal crisis was not settled congregation by congregation. The apostles and presbyters gathered, debated, and issued a decree, it seemed good to the Holy Ghost and to us, and the decree was delivered to churches that had not been in the room and bound them, for as they went through the cities, they delivered them the decrees for to keep, that were ordained of the apostles and elders (Acts 16:4). The New Testament pattern is not autonomous congregations. It is churches in council, the whole first-millennium shape in embryo. And the honest point about offices is conceded, not dodged: bishop and presbyter are one office in the New Testament, and this site grants it in a paper of its own and will not unsay it here. But nothing in that concession yields independency, for the presbyters of Acts act synodally, and Titus receives external authority to appoint elders town by town. The honest low-church claim buys presbyterianism at most. It never bought the lone congregation that answers to nobody.

Commit thou to faithful men (2 Timothy 2:2). The things that thou hast heard of me among many witnesses, the same commit thou to faithful men, who shall be able to teach others also. Count the generations in the sentence: Paul, Timothy, the faithful men, the others also, four

links of a relay in one verse, from the apostle's own pen. The handing over of teaching to ordained and accountable men who hand it over in turn is not a catholic accretion on the New Testament. It is a command inside it, and the succession this page keeps pointing to is that verse walking through history.

The pillar and ground of the truth (1 Timothy 3:15). Asked to name the guardian of the truth, Paul does not say the book he was writing. He says the house of God, which is the church of the living God, the pillar and ground of the truth. The noun is architecture, weight-carrying and visible, and a reader who holds that the true church is invisible or that the book guards itself is arguing with the verse's own grammar. The Scriptures are the treasure. The verse names the building they were kept in.

Obey them that have the rule over you (Hebrews 13:17). And submit yourselves, for they watch for your souls, as they that must give account. Here is the whole shape in one breath: an ordered ministry, real authority, and an audit above it, the office and its accounting together. The verse does not know a congregation with no one to obey, and it does not know a leader who answers to no one. It knows the ancient shape, shepherds under the Shepherd.

This do in remembrance of me (Luke 22:19, 1 Corinthians 10 and 11). Remembrance granted. The cup of blessing which we bless, is it not the communion of the blood of Christ. The bread which we break, is it not the communion of the body of Christ. And whosoever eats and drinks unworthily is guilty of the body and blood of the Lord, eating and drinking damnation to himself, not discerning the Lord's body. Nobody is guilty of a metaphor. Justin said the same thing a century later, not as common bread, and the first millennium never said less.

The first millennium was not low church

The oldest church building we possess, the house church at Dura-Europos, was walled up around 256 and so stands frozen from before Constantine, and it contains a built baptistery with painted images of Christ on its walls, the Good Shepherd, the healing of the paralytic. Pliny, a pagan governor, reported to the emperor Trajan around 112 that the Christians met before dawn on a fixed day and sang by turns a hymn to Christ as to a god, which is liturgy, described by a policeman. St. Justin, around 155, describes the Sunday assembly, the memoirs of the apostles read, the presider's homily, the common prayers, and the bread and cup received not as common bread, with deacons carrying the gifts to the absent, the skeleton of every ancient rite, ninety years after Paul. And the Didache, the church's oldest manual, commands fasting on the fourth day and the Preparation and the Lord's Prayer three times daily, a calendar and a rule of prayer before the New Testament was fully gathered.

And the Bible itself testifies first. The Jerusalem church devoted itself to the apostles' teaching and fellowship, to the breaking of bread and the prayers, Acts 2:42, and the Greek says the prayers, a definite article, fixed prayers at fixed hours, for these were worshipers formed in temple and synagogue who kept attending both. Paul hands on the Supper in the language of sacred tradition, I received from the Lord what I also delivered to you, and hands on the resurrection faith the same way, a formula to be kept. The first crisis was settled by a council whose decree bound churches that were not in the room, as the verses section above read in full. The letters to Timothy and Titus order a ministry with qualifications, ordination by the laying on of hands, and public reading of Scripture in the assembly. And when heaven opens in the Revelation of John, the worship there is an altar, a sea of glass, incense, white robes, and the thrice-holy hymn, which is to say that the one book of the Bible set inside heaven's own liturgy shows something far more like the ancient rites than like a rented hall. The New Testament church was small and poor and hunted. Nothing in its own book says it was low.

Then come the men the apostles taught, and they are the receipt the argument cannot survive. Clement of Rome, writing about the year 96, while John may still have been alive, commands that offerings be made at the appointed times and hours, for the Master has commanded order, and grounds the ministry in succession from the apostles. Ignatius of Antioch, a decade later, on the road to the lions, writes to church after church of the bishop, the presbyters, and the deacons, and of one Eucharist. These are not medieval accretions. These are the apostles' own students, writing within living memory, describing order, liturgy, and altar as the normal inheritance, and even on the latest scholarly datings these letters stand generations before any record of a free congregation. And here is the silence that ends the debate: the early church recorded every controversy it had. We possess the fights over circumcision, over the date of Easter, over rebaptism, over the lapsed, in painful detail. If the apostles had planted free congregations with free worship, and bishops and liturgies had overthrown that within one generation, everywhere, from Gaul to Persia, it would be the greatest revolution in the Church's history, and the record holds not one line of protest against it. No one anywhere complained that the liturgy had replaced freedom, because no one anywhere had known the thing it supposedly replaced.

So the primitive church the revivalist longs to restore kept a creed at Baptism, a weekly altar, a fast, a calendar, and an ordered ministry, and we possess the documents and the room. The instinct behind low church is real and old, the fear of dead form, and the first millennium feared it first, which is why the desert fathers fled the comfortable churches. But note where they fled, into more Psalter, not less, into a stricter rule, not none. The remedy for dead form was living form. It was never no form.

And there is a law underneath all these exhibits, the one this site's own Lex orandi page is named for. The law of prayer is the law of belief: a church comes to believe, over time, what its worship rehearses. The ancient liturgies were doctrine sung, the creed at Baptism, the Gloria, the anaphora confessing the Trinity every Sunday whether the preacher was sound that morning or not, so the people's faith had guardrails that did not depend on the pulpit. Here is low church's Achilles heel, and it is structural, not spiritual. Where the whole service is a sermon and songs, the congregation's belief rests on one man's doctrine and this year's lyrics, and it can drift in a generation without anyone deciding anything. The liturgy carries implicitly what the creeds state explicitly, and a church that drops both has removed both rails from the same bridge. The Assemblies learned it in two years. The free churches differ so widely from one another not because they read different Bibles, but because nothing in the room says the same words twice.

The historians' verdict

The historians concede this across every party line. Lightfoot, the great Anglican scholar, proved the letters of Ignatius genuine against a century of doubters who wished them forged precisely because of what they show. Philip Schaff, Protestantism's own historian of the church, records the ordered ministry and the liturgy in the second century as plain fact, and Schaff had standing to say so, for in 1845 his own synod tried him for heresy for teaching that Protestantism grows from the catholic root, and acquitted him. Even Harnack, the great liberal historian who regretted what he found, documented the ordered, liturgical, creedal church of the second century as plain fact, the strongest kind of testimony there is, the witness who wished it otherwise. The dispute among scholars is over what the order means, never over whether it was there.

Newman gave the test that sorts this, and his book is on the Sources shelf of this site. A true development preserves the type of the thing developing, as the oak preserves the acorn's kind, and by that test the church of Justin is recognizably the sapling of the church of the councils, creed at the water, bishop at the altar, Scripture in the assembly, the same organism grown. Turn the test around and the restorationist claim falls apart: if the free congregation with free worship were the original organism, then everything in the record from Clement onward is not development but replacement, a different creature wearing the Church's name from the first generation after the apostles. Newman looked at exactly this evidence and wrote the sentence that has stung ever since, that to be deep in history is to cease to be a Protestant. This page does not ask the reader to go that far, for the book keeps Newman's test and declines his destination, holding that the deep current runs past 1870's claims as well, to the shared millennium. It asks him only to go as deep as the year 96 and say what he finds there.

And Jaroslav Pelikan, the Lutheran pastor's son who wrote the century's five-volume history of doctrine and gave the age its best sentence on this page's subject, that tradition is the living faith of the dead and traditionalism the dead faith of the living, ended his own road received into Orthodoxy at seventy-four, which this page reports as history and decides for no one. Three centuries of scholars, none of them Roman when they started, one direction of travel.

Where the table of contents came from

Open the Bible to its table of contents and notice what is not there: a verse listing the books. The list itself is nowhere inside the covers. Sixty-six times the believer trusts a book, and the trust rests on an act Scripture never records, the whole Church's slow reception of her own canon. The record of that act survives. Around 170 the Muratorian fragment lists most of the New Testament and openly notes what is disputed. For two centuries the disputed books, Hebrews, James, the Revelation, are called disputed in public, by bishops, without panic. In 367 Athanasius, the bishop who saved the creed, circulates the first list matching the New Testament as the reader holds it, and the councils at Hippo and Carthage receive rather than invent it. Core first, edges slowly, no tribunal ever slamming the cover, and the edges are held open to this day.

And the channel never closed. Luther doubted James to its face, called it an epistle of straw in 1522, and his own tradition kept James over its founder, reception overruling the reformer inside his own tradition. The King James of 1611 was printed with the books between the testaments, and they left the family Bible not by any council's act but by a Bible society's economy in the 1820s, so the shelf of the sternest Bible-only household is itself a monument to reception. The believer who trusts his table of contents already practices catholicity every time he opens the book. He has only never been told. And the same hand that passed the book passed the rule for reading it, for Irenaeus wrote out the rule of faith the churches taught every candidate before the water, and Tertullian answered the sects who quoted Scripture cleverly with a lawyer's point, that the Scriptures belong to the churches that received them from the apostles. The canon and the creed came down together, the list and the lens, and a man who takes the list has already taken the hand.

The three ways around the record

The claim that low church rediscovers what the whole Church lost is the total form of an old claim, that the gospel itself was lost until Luther found it, a form Augsburg itself refused, professing to depart from the church catholic in nothing. The total form fails three ways. It cannot date the loss, for the record runs continuous from the Didache to Clement to Ignatius to

Justin to the councils, with no gap where the free church could have died. It proves too much, for the canon of Scripture itself was gathered and certified by that very church, as the section above on the table of contents showed, so the Bible falls with the church the claim condemns. And it dishonors the promise, for a church that lost the gospel, or lost true worship, within a century of Pentecost is a church the gates of hell prevailed against almost immediately, which no reader of Matthew 16 can grant.

And past its three failures, the restorationist premise keeps company a Christian should be introduced to, for the story of a church that fell and a latecomer who restores it is the founding myth of nearly every religion built on Christianity's edges. The gnostics told it first, a secret truth the public church had lost, and Irenaeus answered them in the second century by pointing to the open succession of the bishops, the very order this page has been defending. Islam tells it, the revelation corrupted until a prophet restored it. Mormonism tells it as formal doctrine, a Great Apostasy healed by Joseph Smith. The Watch Tower tells it, the church fallen from the apostles' death until Russell recovered the truth. The premise is always the same, that the gates of hell prevailed and a latecomer reopened them, and a Christian argument that borrows this premise has borrowed the cornerstone of the religions it exists to refute. The company a premise keeps is not by itself proof against it, but a man should know his co-signers.

This site holds, with the whole ancient Church, that Christ preserves His whole Body from final failure, a promise held of the whole across her divisions and not of any single see, so one communion stumbling breaks no promise. But the restoration claim is not about one communion. It says the whole visible Church, East and West, Gaul to Persia, lost true worship and true order within a generation of the apostles, and the record shows no remnant anywhere carrying the true thing quietly, though some have tried to invent one, a hidden trail of true churches persisting unseen through the centuries, which the documents refuse at every point. So the claim, weighed plainly, is whole-Body defection. And whole-Body defection is not a Protestant conclusion, it is the end of Christianity, for if the Church universally failed that early and stayed failed that long, then the promise of Matthew 16 failed, and He who made it was mistaken, and there is nothing left worth restoring. The sedevacantist saws the same branch from the other side, a see empty for seventy years, an absurdity arrived at by rigor, and the restorationist version is the same absurdity at larger scale. Followed to its floor, the argument for low church is an argument that Christianity is false, and no Christian may keep it. Its opposite is this page's whole comfort: the shape was never lost because the Body cannot finally fail, which is why the free churches have something to pick up at all.

There is a third form of the claim, subtler than restoration and older than the tract, that the true Church was always invisible, a hidden remnant known to God, so the visible record proves nothing. Grant what is true in it, for the Lord knoweth them that are his, and the book this site

defends confesses the Church at once visible and invisible. But the reading cannot survive its own New Testament. Letters were carried to churches at Corinth, at Philippi, at Rome, with addresses, and no letter can be delivered to an invisible church. The Revelation shows seven candlesticks with seven names and warns that a candlestick can be removed out of his place, which is only a threat if the candlestick can be seen. Paul calls the church of the living God the pillar and ground of the truth, and a pillar is architecture. The Lord himself said a city that is set on an hill cannot be hid. An invisible remnant may comfort a reader against the record, but the apostles kept writing down addresses.

The third escape is the Baptist's own, and its instinct is the truest thing in it. Landmarkism taught, and Carroll's Trail of Blood tract of 1931 spread through a thousand Sunday schools, an unbroken chain of true baptist churches from the Jordan to the present, hidden in the persecuted margins, Paulicians, Albigenses, Waldensians. Honor the instinct completely: even the tradition that rejects bishops invented a succession, because every Christian knows in his bones that the Church must be continuous or the promise failed. The difference is the record. The documented line runs Clement, Ignatius, Polycarp, names, cities, letters the reader can open tonight on this site, while the tract's line runs through medieval dualists who denied the incarnation and refused the water, links that fail the chain's own Baptist test. He was right that a trail must exist. He was tracing the wrong blood. The true trail is ink, it is unbroken, and it is free.

When the first-century claim collapses, the fallback is always Constantine, the church fell when the empire embraced her. But every exhibit above predates Constantine, Clement by two centuries, the painted baptistery by sixty years, and the fallback fails a harder test besides, for history ran the experiment. The Church of the East separated in 431 and lived in Persia, outside the Roman Empire altogether, beyond Constantine's reach from the beginning. The Oriental churches separated in 451 and kept Egypt, Armenia, and Ethiopia behind their own mountains for fifteen centuries. These are the control group, sealed off early and keeping their own line of descent, and if the high shape were an imperial corruption, the sealed churches would show the primitive low form. They show the opposite, bishops, liturgies, and altars older and stricter than Rome's own. Every independent line, kept separately for a thousand years and more, arrives at the same shape, and independent witnesses agreeing is what proof looks like.

The men accused of trading the apostles' freedom for institution are the men the lions ate, for Ignatius wrote of the bishop's office on the road to his own execution, and corruptors do not ordinarily die for the thing they corrupted. The low churchman already trusts this church's judgment on questions far harder than worship, for he received the Trinity and the two natures of Christ from her councils, and her worship was a public fact she could hardly have been mistaken about, so to take her word on the inner life of God while refusing it on whether she had bishops is selectivity pointed backward. And the restorations refute one another, for every

man who rebuilds the primitive church from the Bible alone builds a different one, the Landmarkist his hidden trail, Campbell his weekly Supper, the Quaker his silence, the Pentecostal his upper room, and a method that cannot converge on the thing it claims to recover is testifying against itself, while the documents, wherever they are dug up, converge on one shape. The date of the loss cannot be found, the control group agrees, the martyrs bled for the order, the method scatters, and the premise, followed to its floor, ends outside the faith.

If low church is true, then the Bible has no table of contents, as the canon's own story above told in full. If low church is true, then nearly every Christian who ever lived died unbaptized, for the infant Baptism the credobaptist refuses was the practice of the whole Church for fifteen centuries, Athanasius, Augustine, every martyr's child, and the Reformers themselves, so the claim quietly unbaptizes the very cloud of witnesses it sings about. If low church is true, then Sunday itself is an overreach, for no verse commands the change of the day, and the church that worships on the first day of the week is trusting the very reception it denies, as it also does every Christmas and every Easter, keeping the two oldest feasts of a calendar it says it does not have. If low church is true, then the Reformation did not go far enough and stands condemned by its own children, for Luther and Calvin kept the infant Baptism, the creed, and the councils' christology, trusting the church's continuity exactly where the modern low churchman refuses to. Every arm of the conditional lands in the same place the premise already landed, outside the faith.

If the Church cannot finally fail, then the canon is safe, the baptisms were real, the martyrs' churches were churches, and everything the free churches love, the Scriptures, the gospel, the fervor, is safer inside the received shape than outside it. The low churchman is not asked to lose one true thing. He is asked to stop holding the one premise that would cost him everything.

What was actually lost, and actually rediscovered at the Reformation, were particular truths inside a living church, which is the book's whole account of reform. What was never lost, because it never left, was the shape: creed, water, altar, order. You cannot rediscover what the documents show never went missing. You can only receive it.

Three escapes, one motive, and the motive is sound: the record must be survivable. It is. The way to survive it is to receive it. And the reader who arrived carrying a different objection than these will find his own, stated at full strength and answered, among the fifty objections on their own page.

How the divisions multiplied

In 1054 the East and the West divided. In 1517 the West divided. And then dividing itself became heritable. Each division made the next one easier, each generation's church was younger, smaller, and more alone than its father's, and the line runs downhill from communions to denominations to movements to ministries, until founding a church became something one man can do with a rented storefront and a doctrinal statement, which is not a freedom the first fifteen centuries would have recognized as church at all.

When the mainlines fell at the morals row, the confessional bodies stood, Missouri that never bent, the orthodox Presbyterians beside the body they left, and the sheep whose pulpit fell had a refuge inside his own tradition. But the pruned learn pruning. A tradition whose reflex is departure will depart again, from itself, over less, forever, and the proof is every strip mall in America with three churches that used to be one.

And yet the drift back toward binding has already begun inside these very churches, on their own initiative, with nobody asking. The Global Methodist Church formed in 2022 and kept the doctrinal standards and kept the bishops, a young church choosing to bind more than it had to. The Assemblies of God organized in 1914 on no creed but the Bible and wrote a binding Statement of Fundamental Truths within two years, because the New Issue controversy of 1913 to 1916 was losing the Trinity itself down the hall, and a creed was the only tool that could stop it. That is the Nicene story replayed at fast forward, and it is the clearest exhibit this page owns that low church is not a neutral architecture, for what a church does not bind it cannot keep. And the Southern Baptist Convention, the largest no-creed body in America, spent Nicaea's anniversary years formally debating whether to bind the Nicene Creed into the Baptist Faith and Message. Motions were brought at Indianapolis in 2024 and pressed again at Dallas in 2025, and at Orlando in 2026 more were offered, none voted down, two sent to the Executive Committee for a year of study, so the question is alive as this page is written. In the same seasons the Convention made its own confession harder to amend, two thirds at two consecutive meetings. However it ends, the argument of this page was had, out loud, on the floor of the least creedal body in America, in Nicaea's own anniversary.

This is how the faith has always spread. Nobody decreed any of it. Confession is spreading, or not, one communion at a time, visibly, now.

The Reformers meant to be catholics

Luther was an Augustinian friar who posted theses for an academic debate inside the church he served, and he was thrown out of it, not walked out. He kept the creed, the infant Baptism, the real presence, the crucifix, and the shape of the Mass in German, and when men began calling their congregations by his name he was disgusted, asking that no one call themselves Lutherans but only Christians, for the doctrine was not his. Augsburg, his party's confession, professes to depart from the church catholic in nothing. A man who is expelled from his communion while protesting that he teaches nothing new is many things, but he is not the founder of a new religion, and he never once thought he was.

Calvin is the line the Presbyterians descend from, through Knox, and he was more explicit still. Commenting on the creed's article, he wrote that the Church is called catholic, or universal, because there could not be two or three churches without Christ being divided, which cannot happen, and he taught that the church is the mother of all who have God for their Father, no salvation outside her nurture, which is language a modern evangelical would call Romish if he did not know its author. When Cranmer proposed a general council of the reformed churches to heal their divisions, Calvin answered that he would cross ten seas for such a unity if he could be of service. Ten seas, for a council. That is not the temperament of a church planter. Knox carried Calvin's reform to Scotland as the reform of the Kirk, the one church of that nation, and from the Kirk through Westminster runs the straight road to the Presbyterian column in part one.

Cranmer is the honest complication. The archbishop moved between high and low in his own lifetime, his first prayer book of 1549 keeping the old shape almost whole, his second of 1552 lowering it, his doctrine of the Supper migrating beneath him as he wrote, and the Anglican tension between altar and pulpit is his biography made liturgy. But mark where even Cranmer's lowest point stood: a national church, with bishops, a fixed liturgy, a calendar, and the creed at every service. The lowest church the Reformers ever built stands higher than the top of this page's bottom row, and none of them, not once, imagined worship without creed, order, or rite.

So take the charge that is always aimed at them, that the Reformation did not go far enough, and hold it up against the tree above. The ones who went further are the tree's bottom, and every further step shed another received mark, the bishops, then the creed, then the Supper's weekly gift, then the water's grace, until the newest churches carry almost nothing and split while carrying it. Whether the Reformation went too far, the charts show, red X by red X. That it went far enough no honest reader of the tree can doubt. Going further was never fidelity to the Reformers. It was the unraveling of everything they refused to surrender.

And this is why, with hindsight, not one of these men would join the non-denominational church that claims their legacy. Luther would not lend his name to a congregation. Calvin would sail ten seas to prevent one more division. Knox reformed a nation's church rather than found his own. They saw themselves, all of them, as faithful catholics contending for the one holy catholic and apostolic Church against what they judged to be her captors, and they would look at the bottom of the tree, ten thousand congregations with ten thousand statements, and recognize nothing of themselves in it. Today we admit the divisions they could not heal. But we are not in the business of creating more of them, and the whole project of the Mere Catholicity papers and this site is to put a stop to it.

The gospel was not lost either

And the deepest fear can be retired with a date. The grace the evangelical guards with his life was confessed by a council in 529, at Orange, which condemned the teaching that faith's beginning lies in ourselves and confessed faith itself as God's gift, a millennium before the Reformation, received in the West. The sixteenth-century quarrel was real, and the book asks Rome to set down Trent's sole-account claim, with the Joint Declaration of 1999 read as corroboration and not closure. But the gospel of grace is not the Reformation's invention held against catholicity. It is part of the deposit this page is asking him to bind, and binding catholicity does not risk his gospel, it gives his gospel a genealogy.

The Puritans, and their heirs

The Puritans held the Calvinist confessions, Westminster and its congregational twin the Savoy Declaration, worship regulated by Scripture alone, the Psalms sung, the Sabbath kept whole, a seriousness about God the modern church has lost, the images broken, the bishops refused, and in New England the congregational way, every church its own final court. They kept much and broke much, and both inheritances are still walking around.

Jonathan Edwards was a Congregationalist, and he was the greatest theological mind America has produced. He preached the revivals, wrote Religious Affections to test them, and loved the glory of God with an intensity his heirs still borrow. And in 1750 his own congregation voted him out of his pulpit, by an overwhelming margin, over who should be admitted to the Supper, the split council of neighboring churches powerless to save him. The greatest theologian on the continent, removed by vote of his own congregation over the Eucharist, with no standing synod anywhere to hear an appeal. His last years were spent preaching to a frontier mission. One life holds the whole congregational question.

And the line thinned as it ran. The churches of the Mathers and of Edwards furnished a Unitarian Harvard by 1805 and lost their meetinghouses at Dedham by 1820, each congregation its own court until the courts changed their minds, and there was no one to appeal to. The modern man who calls Edwards his master is John Piper, and no one alive has sent more readers back to Edwards, an honor this page salutes without irony. But mark the line's direction. Piper is a Baptist. The heirs of the Puritans now stand outside the Puritans' own Baptism and polity, and each generation of the line has bound less than its fathers, Westminster to Savoy to the 1689 to a statement of faith, which is the thinning this whole page is about, drawn in one family tree.

One confession, three churches

The confessional core of the free-church world is one family of three churches. The Presbyterian holds the Westminster Confession of 1646. The Congregationalist holds the Savoy Declaration of 1658, which is Westminster rewritten with congregational polity. The Reformed Baptist holds the Confession of 1689, which is Savoy rewritten with believer's Baptism. Same doctrine of God, same Scriptures, same morals, three polities. The Presbyterian column is carried over from part one, marks and all, because the family is best measured against its own eldest communion.

✓ confessed in the communion's binding standards.

? substance affirmed while mode or formula stands open, or the question still alive in the tradition's own texts, doctors, or courts.

✗ not confessed in the standards as they stand, and nothing more. It does not mean do not worship there. It means the man who holds the whole first millennium in that communion will need an exception or two to his confession's paper, and a man may confess more than his standard. And the mark reverses its meaning across the chart. Among the received rows a red X marks a gap between a communion's paper and the received faith. Among the set-down rows it marks only what that communion never bound alone, which is no fault at all. No mark on this chart puts anyone out of the Body of Christ, and the notes carry the argument the glyphs cannot. The chart measures confessions, not Christians. Every column baptizes into the one Body, and every red X among the received rows is healable by the hand that set it. Each column's case follows the chart. These charts read every open question at its most generous defensible edge, and the book, which argues the full case, sometimes weighs the same evidence more strictly. The two never disagree about the receipts, only about how much hope to print, and the notes carry both.

History gives every ✗ among the received rows hope. The Church of the East refused the council of Ephesus, and the churches of Egypt, Armenia, and Syria refused Chalcedon, yet each confessed all along, in its own words, the very faith those councils defended, and the agreed statements of our own day record the match. The refusals stayed on paper while the faith itself was received. Reception can close a gap from both sides, and it has done so before. What that hope asks of each communion, the cases below say by name.

The faith confessed	Presbyterian (carried over)	Congregational	Reformed Baptist
RECEIVED BY THE WHOLE CHURCH IN THE FIRST MILLENNIUM			
The Holy Scriptures	✓	✓	✓
The Nicene Creed	✓	✓	✓
The christology of the seven councils	✓	✓	✓

The faith confessed	Presbyterian (carried over)	Congregational	Reformed Baptist
Mary the Theotokos, Mother of God (Ephesus)	??§	??§	??§
The veneration of the holy icons (Nicaea II)	?***	?***	×
The apostolic succession of bishops	?*	?*	?*
The real presence in the Eucharist (corporeal)	?**	?**	×*****
The regeneration given in Baptism	??§§	??§§	×
The moral consensus of the Fathers (life, marriage, holy orders)	✓	✓	✓
BOUND BY ONE CHURCH ALONE, AND SO NOT RECEIVED BY THE WHOLE			
The Westminster Confession as binding (1646)	✓	×	×
The Savoy Declaration as binding (1658)	×	✓	×
The Baptist Confession as binding (1689)	×	×	✓

The Presbyterian marks are part one's, their apparatus carried over beneath this chart as well, Westminster cited by chapter, Calvin and the Mercersburg school, the amendment of 1788, and the healable mark. All three churches keep Westminster's clause on the Mother of God, the Son taking man's nature of the substance of the Virgin. From 1646 to 1689, across two rewrites and forty-three years, exactly one received chapter changed in the text itself, the grace of Baptism, and everything else the family kept word for word. Polity moved twice, the water moved once, and the confession of God did not move at all, which is both the honor of this family and the warning, for the chapter that moved is the one the whole Church had held longest. The marks part company in two more rows beyond the water, the Supper and the images, and not because the words differ, for they mostly do not. They part along the lives, as the notes below explain: where the question is alive in a church, in its doctors, its courts, or its own thinner text, the cell holds a question, and where a church has read its words and settled, the cell holds the settlement. The Reformed Baptist column, which reads hardest, is noted apart at ll.

* Their pastors are ordained by presbyters rather than bishops, and whether presbyteral succession preserves the ministry is a real question, worked out in The bishop and the presbyter. The book records both readings, walks the narrower in its own map, and does not close the question.

§ As on part one: the Westminster text all three churches keep entails the doctrine, the Son taking man's nature of the substance of the Virgin, but never uses the title. The formula differs, the faith is received.

This page says the Supper because that is the name these churches' own standards use, Westminster's chapter is Of the Lord's Supper, and a page that reads every church from its own papers reports each in its own vocabulary. In its own voice, on part one and in the Credo, this site speaks as the first millennium spoke: the Eucharist, the altar, the sacrifice, the memorial of the one offering. The Lord's Supper is Scripture's own name for the meal (1 Corinthians 11:20), and the altar is the whole Church's name for what she found the meal to be. The climb from the first name to the second is part of the picking up this page asks.

** On the presence the row asks the corporeal confession, and the Reformed standards give a divided answer, which is what the question mark records. Westminster's own words affirm the substance: worthy receivers really and indeed, yet not carnally and corporally but spiritually, receive and feed upon Christ crucified, the body and blood of Christ being as really, but spiritually, present to the faith of believers as the elements themselves are to their outward senses (Westminster Confession 29). A true feeding on the true body and blood, confessed. What the confession refuses is the corporeal mode, the elements remaining bread and wine, and whether that refusal reaches the confessed thing itself or only one description of it is precisely the question the mark leaves open, for the tradition's own doctors answered it both ways. Princeton read the confession down, Hodge's presence of virtue and effect, and it was Princeton's lower reading the churches largely followed. But Calvin himself sits green on this row by his own words, "we are truly made partakers of the proper substance of the body and blood of Jesus Christ" (Short Treatise on the Lord's Supper, 1541), and Nevin's Mystical Presence of 1846 argued that the original Reformed doctrine was "a real communication with his substantial, personal, mediatorial life." The school has a name, Mercersburg theology, from the seminary where Nevin and Philip Schaff taught, called by its friends high church Presbyterianism or sacramental Calvinism, in our day Reformed catholicity, and scholars now grant that Nevin had the history right. The confessional high-water marks agree with him: the Belgic Confession calls what we eat and drink "the true, natural body and the true blood of Christ," and the Scots Confession of 1560 utterly damns those who say the sacraments are naked and bare signs. So the cell is read with both readings on the table: with Hodge it would be red, with Calvin it would be green, and the standards as they stand bind neither, which is the question mark's exact meaning in this chart's legend. The direction of travel is the good news, for the recovery of Calvin's own doctrine is the living school in these churches, and a tradition walking back toward its founder is walking toward this row's green. What would settle it is plain: chapter 29 read, taught, and in time amended by the tradition's own oldest stratum, Calvin, the Belgic, and the Scots, the church healing itself from its own beginnings, as the American church amended Westminster's own chapters on the civil magistrate in 1788 and subscribes the amended text to this day, and an agreed statement recording the match, as 1994 recorded one for the East. And the Congregational question mark has its own ceiling named: Owen, whose discourses on the Supper feed on the body and blood in terms Geneva would own.

**** The Baptist X on the presence stands beside his cousins' question marks, and the difference is not the words, for the 1689's chapter 30 tracks Westminster's 29 word for word. The difference is the tradition holding the words. His teaching and practice of the Supper long ago settled memorial-ward,

and no living school within his tradition presses toward Calvin's realism with Mercersburg's weight, though the ceiling shows even in his own library, for Spurgeon himself preached a true and real presence at the Supper, spiritual and no fiction, and Keach's own catechism answers that the worthy receivers are, by faith, made partakers of his body and blood. Part one's note weighs two live readings and finds the standards binding neither. Among the Presbyterians both readings live. Among the Baptists the reading has settled, downward, so the mark stands red, with the same road open that his case names, and no assembly to wait for.

|| The Reformed Baptist column, noted apart, because his reality and his cousins' diverge more than the shared words show. On the Supper, the ***** note above. On the holy icons his paper is as thin as the Savoy's, the worship-scoped clause of his own chapter 22 and a catechism that forbids the worshipping of God by images and nothing more, so the red stands not on a stricter text but on a settled reading: his tradition has read the thin clause at its widest from the meetinghouse onward, the worship bare by conviction, there is no court above the congregation where a wider reading could be excepted, and text, reading, and life agree. The road out is the shortest on the chart, the same local vote that settled the reading, the Assyrian posture one congregational meeting away. On the water his confession refuses the infant and the instrument together, an ordinance of obedience testifying to a grace already given, and the two ancient receipts that weigh against it, Origen and Cyprian, stand beneath the second chart. The column reads harder than his cousins' not because his words are harder but because his churches have read them harder, and the congregational speed that set every mark can move every mark.

§§ The Reformed standards do not deny the grace of Baptism but untie it from the moment of the act. The grace promised is really exhibited and conferred by the Holy Ghost in God's appointed time (Westminster Confession 28.6), and what is refused is the binding of the gift to the minute of the washing. A grace affirmed but untied is a question, not a refusal.

*** The papers are not one paper, and the marks differ because the texts and the adjudications differ. The Presbyterian cell is a question by the tradition's own courts, carried in full in part one's note: the exception touching images of Christ used for teaching stands among the most commonly taken and granted in the presbyteries' own records, so what his strictest paper finally binds is a question his tradition has not closed. The Congregational cell is a question by his own thinner text, for the Savoy he holds carries only the worship-scoped clause, God not worshiped under any visible representation, while the explicit condemnation of making the image lives in the Larger Catechism, the Presbyterian's subscribed paper and never his, so the reach of his clause toward the child's Bible was never bound at all. Neither mark is a check and cannot be, for the row is veneration, and veneration is practiced by no one here. The Reformed Baptist column is noted apart at ||. The ask for all remains the Assyrian step, the end of condemnation, after which these cells rest as the Assyrian's does, condemning nothing and required to venerate nothing.

What catholicity asks of the Westminster family

The Presbyterian case. His case is carried in full on part one, where his communion stands beside the historic ones. He leads this family toward catholicity, and the paragraph above says why.

The Congregational case. His ask is a synod, and the answer to it is buried in his own founding papers. The Cambridge Platform of 1648, New England's own constitution, calls synods an ordinance of Christ, and Connecticut's Saybrook Platform of 1708 gave its councils real teeth for a century. Congregationalism with binding councils is not an import from Rome or Geneva, it is his own tradition's road not taken, and Dedham happened where that ordinance lay unused, the meetinghouses lost because the churches of the Mathers had built the court and left it empty. So the concrete ask is small and entirely his: let the fellowship's annual meeting become what Cambridge called it, an ordinance and not a conference, with the moral consensus and the creed as its first two cares. On the sacraments his Savoy tracks Westminster, so part one's roads are his, the Supper through Calvin and Mercersburg, the water already at a question mark on his own covenant logic. That is how catholicity is held in a Congregational church, by reading the Cambridge Platform as seriously as the men who wrote it did. And the road is not untrod, for his Presbyterian brother walks it ahead of him, and following him toward catholicity is following his own confession home.

The Reformed Baptist case. His confession is the richest on this chart, and its own preface is his first lever, for the men of 1689 wrote that they used the very words of Westminster and Savoy on purpose, to declare their hearty agreement with the family. So amending toward the family's older stratum is not a betrayal of the 1689, it is the 1689's founding instinct. And his polity moves faster than the Presbyterian's, for there are no courts to refuse him: the confession binds his congregation because his congregation adopted it, and what a congregation adopted a congregation can amend, by the vote of its own members. On the Supper his chapter 30 tracks Westminster's 29 word for word, so the road part one maps, Calvin's proper substance and the amended chapter, lies open to him too, and faster, for no assembly need vote before his congregation reads its own chapter at Westminster's height. On the holy icons his catechism keeps Westminster's condemnation, and the same local vote can retire the condemning while practicing nothing, the Assyrian posture. The hard one is the water. His chapter 29 refuses the infant and the instrument together, and this page asks only what the note above asks, that Origen and Cyprian be let into the elders' study, a tradition from the apostles and a council of sixty-six bishops debating not whether but when. That is how catholicity is held in a Reformed Baptist congregation, and held faster than anywhere else in his family, because nobody can tell his congregation no, which is Dedham's blade held by the other end, so let the speed serve the received faith, and let it follow his Presbyterian cousin, who leads this family toward catholicity, with nothing between the 1689 man and walking beside him except a vote his own congregation can take this year.

Are these not free churches too, the Presbyterian included? In the word's own sense, churches free of the state, they all are. Part one ends where the book ends, at the communions the book weighs in its tiers, and the Presbyterian stands there as the Reformation's confessional witness beside the Lutheran. This page charts what the book did not chart, by the same nine rows. The boundary between the pages is order, not honor, the order of the book's own treatment, and the Methodist, who kept his courts and his bishops, is honored below for exactly that. The Presbyterian column was carried over precisely so the family would not be divided by a page break.

Presbyterianism is, in this site's judgment, the best thing going among the Reformation's heirs on this page. It is the one tradition here that binds a whole confession and means it, with real courts to enforce it and a subscription system candid enough to record its exceptions, which shows it knows what binding is. Its polity is the very thing the bishop-and-presbyter concession buys, government by councils of elders, connectional and accountable, never one man's independent congregation. It kept catechesis when the culture dropped it, and it kept the Psalms when the chorus came. Even its worst habit, dividing over doctrine, is the overflow of its best trait, taking doctrine seriously enough to divide over. That is why the book could set him beside the historic communions at all, and why he stands in part one: he has the most already in hand, and the shortest list of asks.

The name is older than America, but it flourished here as nowhere else. The free churches were the churches free of the state establishments of Europe, and America was the first great nation that never had one, a people broadly Christian by conviction and constitutionally without an official church. Ground with no establishment is open ground, and the free churches, built to live without the crown's favor, were the churches built for it. That is why the American landscape looks like the bottom of this tree, and why this page had to be written in America.

Christian Reconstructionism, the theonomic movement of Rushdoony and his heirs, proposes to bind what the confessions never bound, a program of biblical civil law and a required postmillennialism, and its harder corners have written plainly that religious liberty is a tactic for the present, to be withdrawn from the enemies of God once a Christian order stands. Say it plainly: a Calvinism that would make the Mass illegal is not conservative Presbyterianism, it is an attack on catholicity itself, aimed at the very communions the morals row shows standing beside the Reformed in the trenches. The standards themselves are wiser. Westminster, Savoy, and the 1689 bind no millennial position at all, and amillennial and postmillennial readings have lived side by side in all three churches from the beginning, which is the old confessions' quiet rebuke to every school that binds a timetable, this one included. The school is loud just now, and loudness is not reception. Most Presbyterians are not in this, these charts measure the standards and not the school, and the reader who meets it should know the difference.

The regulative principle

The regulative principle teaches that worship may include only what Scripture commands, and state it at full strength first: it was born of real revulsion at real abuse, and its fruits include the Psalms sung and a seriousness this page has honored from its first section. But weigh the principle by its own rule and it fails at the door, for the principle itself is commanded nowhere in Scripture, so the rule that only the commanded may enter worship enters worship uncommanded. The synagogue's whole order of service is commanded nowhere in the Law, and the Lord attended it as his custom was. The fixed hours, the Wednesday and Friday fasts, and the ordered Sunday assembly arose under men taught by the apostles, who saw no violation, as the record above showed. And the principle's own churches could not keep it, for Watts broke exclusive psalmody, the hymnal won, and the living tradition of the Reformed churches has already ruled in practice that the received and the edifying may stand beside the expressly commanded. The fear underneath the principle is right, worship invented by the man up front. But the answer to invented worship is not the bare room, which must invent everything weekly. It is the received rite, which is precisely the worship no one alive invented.

So file the principle where the whole Church's practice files it: a discipline of one tradition, not received by the whole body, and so binding nobody beyond the churches that hold it, and yet a patrimony worth keeping alive. What it protects is real and lovely. The harmonized psalmody of the Reformed churches is among the most beautiful worship Protestants have ever made, and it stands beside Anglican plainchant and the Latin church's Gregorian chant as the same instinct in three tongues, the received words sung in a received way, and all three deserve encouraging among the laity, chant and psalter both being older than every quarrel on this page. The absolute bans are another matter, for an organ banned on principle is a strange casualty of a rule that cannot commend itself, and the last sixty years of guitar-and-coffee-shop worship are a reaction the ban's holders rightly dread but cannot cure, for the cure for invented worship was never silence. It was the received rite, sung.

The men the free churches love

Each of the men the free churches love was reaching back toward the received faith, and their reaching is the evidence that the hunger for catholicity already lives in the free churches. John Wesley is the anchor. An Anglican priest who died one, he preached the duty of constant communion and told his people to receive as often as they could, taught the baptism of infants in his Treatise on Baptism, wrote an irenic Letter to a Roman Catholic in 1749, and in 1784, a presbyter, ordained superintendents for America, then spent his last years refusing to let Asbury call himself bishop. Methodism is the largest living experiment in presbyteral succession, and the bishop and presbyter paper is about it whether Methodism has read the paper or not.

Leonard Ravenhill's indictment of comfortable religion lands on every column of both charts equally, and his tribe by temperament is the desert fathers, who answered the same indictment with a rule of prayer, which is the whole case of Lex orandi. And Keith Green, who wrote tracts against Rome and songs the whole divided Church now sings, and time sorted his work the way it sorts everything: the whole Church kept the songs and let the tracts go, and nobody decreed either.

Richard Allen, ordained by Asbury, walked out of St. George's in Philadelphia when the church that baptized him pulled him from his knees at prayer, and founded the African Methodist Episcopal Church in 1816, keeping the Methodist doctrine, the discipline, and the bishops entire. The Black church in America, the AME, the Baptist conventions, the Church of God in Christ that this tree already names, is the one family whose separations were mostly forced on it rather than chosen, schisms of exclusion suffered, not preferences indulged, and its founders walked out of the white church's sin while carrying the faith's whole shape with them. A page that measures American division owes that distinction in writing, and pays it here.

The two reachers

Two men taught the twentieth-century free churches to hunger for something older than themselves, and they reached in the same direction and stopped at different depths.

	Martyn Lloyd-Jones	A. W. Tozer
Reached back to	the Puritans of the seventeenth century	the catholic mystics, the desert to the cloister
What he fled	a dead orthodoxy, the doctrine without the fire	a busy evangelicalism, the activity without the Presence
What he found	preaching as logic on fire, doctrine felt in the bones	worship as adoration, the pursuit of God Himself
How deep the reach went	three centuries, and stopped at 1650	past the Reformation, deep into the cloister, without telling anyone

Lloyd-Jones, the physician who left medicine for the pulpit of Westminster Chapel, spent thirty years telling evangelicals that their fathers were deeper than their present, and rebuilt a whole generation's library out of the seventeenth century. Tozer, the self-taught pastor from the Alliance, quoted Nicholas of Cusa at length in The Pursuit of God and filled his anthology of mystical verse with catholic voices, Bernard and Faber thick among them, and his readers loved the water without ever asking the name of the well. The hunger in both men is one hunger, and

it points one direction, backward. This page asks nothing of their heirs except to keep walking the way both men were already facing, for the road behind the Puritans and behind the mystics is the same road, and it leads to the same nine rows.

Part III. The young churches

Calvary Chapel, and what it binds

Chuck Smith opened the church door to the barefoot generation when respectable churches would not, baptized thousands in the Pacific, and taught the Bible verse by verse through whole books in order, which is not a modern invention but the oldest preaching there is, Chrysostom's own method, the patristic homily alive in Costa Mesa. Whole fellowships learned the Scriptures from that pulpit who would never have entered any other, and this page counts that among the works of God.

Its statement of faith is real and Trinitarian, yet no ancient creed is required anywhere, and what functions as the working test of fellowship is an end-times system. The dispensational chart, the rapture before the tribulation, the whole timetable, was assembled in the 1830s, and the first millennium never heard of it. The old hope of Christ's return is ancient, and the early chiliasm of Justin and Irenaeus is genuinely first-millennium, so nothing here mocks a Christian for watching the sky. But the system is young, it is held by one corner of one tradition of one schism, and in practice it functions as a point of communion, for fellowship has been broken over the rapture in rooms where nobody was ever asked to say the Nicene Creed. That is the inversion this page exists to name, the newest doctrine bound tightest while the oldest goes unbound. The system is weighed on its own terms just below, and the asking stays what it was: the heirs of Chuck Smith will one day be asked to set it down, held as their own reading and exacted of no one, exactly what this site asks Rome to do with 1870.

The dispensational system

The pretribulational rapture and the dispensational reading of history were assembled in the 1830s in the circle of John Nelson Darby and carried to America in the notes of the Scofield Bible. Before that decade the system appears nowhere. Not in the fathers, not in the councils, not in the Reformers, not in Westminster or Savoy or the 1689 or Augsburg or the Articles, not in Wesley, not in Edwards, not in one liturgy, confession, or catechism of any communion on either of these pages. Newman's test needs one sentence here: a true development preserves the type of what came before, and this system has no before. It is not an acorn grown. It is a graft from nowhere, and to be deep in history is to cease to be a dispensationalist, for one need only go as deep as 1829.

John Nelson Darby was a leader of the Plymouth Brethren in the Dublin of the 1830s, and the two-stage coming took shape in his circle and its prophecy conferences at Powerscourt. His own movement is the system's first exhibit, for the Brethren, born free of every structure, split within a generation into Exclusive and Open and have kept splitting since, the bottom of this page's tree lived out first by the very men who drew the chart. The system crossed the ocean as a marginal note and conquered as one, for the Scofield Reference Bible of 1909 printed the dispensations on the same page as the sacred text, and a generation raised on it could no longer tell where Scripture ended and the chart began. From there the line is short and entirely modern: through the Bible institutes, through Dallas Theological Seminary, founded in 1924 to teach the system as theology, through *The Late Great Planet Earth* in 1970, the best selling book in America of its decade, and into the *Left Behind* novels, tens of millions of copies of fiction doing the catechesis the creeds were never allowed to do. That is the whole pedigree: a Dublin drawing room, a reference Bible's margin, a Texas seminary, and a paperback rack. Set it beside the pedigree of the creed it displaces, Nicaea received by the whole Church for seventeen centuries, and the comparison is the argument.

Do not confuse it with the old hope it wears as a costume. The chiliasm of Justin and Irenaeus was a patient reading of one promise, one public return of Christ, held loosely, never bound, weighed by the Church across centuries and allowed to fade under Augustine's reading without an anathema in either direction. That is how the whole Church handles an open question, and this page defends the ancient chiliast without blinking. The system is not his heir. It binds what he held loosely, and it adds what he never heard of, a second secret coming, a two-stage return, a parenthesis church, and a timetable, none of which any Christian anywhere is recorded as holding for eighteen centuries.

The Church weighed the old hope for centuries, in the open, and Augustine's reading won the field. Justin himself, chiliast as he was, granted that many pious and pure Christians read the promise otherwise, so the question was open from the start. Augustine, who says he once held the millennial reading himself, set out the other account in the twentieth book of the *City of God*: the thousand years are the age of the Church between the two advents, the binding of Satan is the gospel loosed among the nations, the first resurrection is Baptism, and the saints reign with Christ now. From the fifth century to the nineteenth that reading held East and West alike, Rome, the Orthodox, and the separated churches of the Orient with them, and when the Reformation came it did not reopen the question, it closed it harder, for Augsburg condemns the Jewish opinions of a worldly kingdom before the resurrection and the Swiss confession calls them dreams. The amillennial and postmillennial readings are one family, the Augustinian, differing only on the temperature of the hope, and between them they were the reading of essentially every Christian teacher for fourteen hundred years.

Why did Augustine win? Not by decree, for no council ever anathematized the old chiliast, and that restraint is itself the Church's answer. He won by reception, the same channel that sorted the canon, and for reasons the reader can weigh himself. His reading takes Revelation with the whole canon instead of alone, one return, one judgment, a kingdom without end, a King who said his kingdom was not of this world. And the Church had watched the alternative bear its fruit, for the carnal-kingdom hope kept breeding timetables, and she had met that fruit before, at the door Montanus knocked on. So put it to the three old questions, everywhere, always after the early mixture, and by all, across communions that were not even speaking to each other. The whole Church never defined it, and the ancient chiliast keeps his honored seat. But it is the received reading, the field the innovator must take, and the dispensationalist has not taken the field. He has walked past it, chart in hand, without ever meeting the argument.

If the system is true, the Creed is wrong, for the whole Church confesses one return, he shall come again in glory to judge the living and the dead, and a secret extra coming for the rapture is a second advent the Creed does not know and the fathers never preached. If the system is true, the Church herself is a parenthesis, an interlude in a program about someone else, and the gates-of-hell promise was made to an afterthought. If the system is true, God has two peoples forever, and Paul wrote in vain that Christ has made the two one and broken down the dividing wall, one new man in place of the two. And if the system is true, then every Christian who ever read the Bible's ending before 1830 read it wrong, which is the restoration premise again, the same premise this page has already followed to its floor, and the floor has not moved. Every arm lands outside the faith.

The system's anchor text says the saints will be caught up to meet the Lord in the air, and the word for meet, *apantesis*, is the word Scripture uses when the wise virgins go out to meet the bridegroom and walk him in, and when the Roman brethren go out to meet Paul on the Appian Way and escort him into the city. It is the word for a delegation going out to welcome an arriving king into their own gates. The text the system reads as an evacuation describes an arrival. As for the one taken and the other left, read the sentence before it: as in the days of Noah, the flood came and took them all away, and the taken ones in the story are the drowned. The Lord's return is as public as lightning and every eye shall see him, no one knows the day or the hour, and a school whose shelves are charts of the day and the hour has answered its own question about how closely it reads.

The timetable habit has named its dates and been broken by every one, the Millerite midnight of 1844 before the system, the eighty-eight reasons of 1988 inside it, the billboards of 2011 beside it, and after each humiliation the charts are redrawn and rebound. It has broken real fellowship over timetables in rooms where the Creed was never once asked for. And it has taught generations to read the news instead of the Gospels and to let the world burn unpolished, on the

theory that one does not shine brass on a sinking ship, which is a slogan the fathers of the first millennium, who built, planted, healed, and watched, would not have recognized as Christian hope. The fathers watched for Christ. The system watches the news. It is young, it is alone, it is bound where the whole Church bound nothing, and it has failed every test it ever set itself. Set it down.

The gifts of the Spirit

Did the miraculous gifts cease with the apostles? The ancient pattern is not what the cessationist assumes. The record of the ancient communions is thick with signs from end to end. Athanasius the bishop wrote the Life of Antony, visions, discernments, and healings in the desert, under episcopal witness. The accounts of Aquinas say the witnesses at his canonization spoke of him raised off the ground in private prayer. Hildegard, now a doctor of the church, wrote down her visions under obedience and her medical books commend the healing virtues of God's creatures down to the stones. And within living memory Padre Pio bore the wounds, read souls in the confessional by the accounts of thousands, and, when Rome silenced him for years on suspicion, obeyed, which is the detail that matters most. The ancient communions never taught that the gifts ceased. They taught that the gifts submit. Individual doctors wondered at the thinning, Chrysostom among them, and Augustine guessed cessation young and then filled a chapter of the City of God with the healings of his own diocese, which is the pattern entire: remarks, retractions, and never a dogma.

Paul faced a charismatic congregation in Corinth and bound both edges in one chapter: do not forbid speaking in tongues, and let all things be done decently and in order, for the spirits of prophets are subject to prophets, and God is not a God of confusion but of peace. He did not forbid the fire, and he did not let the fire set the furniture's arrangement. And when the second century produced Montanus, whose prophecy claimed to bind the Church with new revelation, the Church defined the one limit she ever dogmatized here: the deposit is closed, and no prophecy adds to it or binds the whole. She judged the prophecies false and the claim to bind intolerable, and she never once defined that prophecy itself had ended. And the gatherings that judged Montanus are the earliest synods on record, councils born to test prophecy, the conciliar instinct present at the start. That is why these charts carry no row for the gifts: the rows hold what the whole Church received as dogma, and on the schedule of the gifts she defined nothing, presumed much, and tested everything. What she received was the frame: a closed deposit, an ordered worship, and the command to test the spirits. Inside that frame, catholicity has been held by wonder-workers and by sober men alike for two thousand years, and this page decides the question for no reader.

The free churches' own fathers lived exactly this tension. Edwards wrote *Religious Affections* to test the revival he himself preached, refusing both the enthusiast who took every swoon for the Spirit and the scoffer who took every swoon for madness, which makes him the free churches' own doctor of discernment, doing in Northampton what the desert fathers did in Egypt. Whitefield, the awakening's greatest voice, took to the fields when the pulpits closed and let the crowds weep without letting the weeping preach. Wesley's journals record healings and strange providences without embarrassment, and when asked why the miracles had thinned since the early church, he answered that the love had thinned, not the Giver, which is nearer the ancient communions' instinct than his critics knew. And Azusa Street's William Seymour prayed with his head inside a wooden crate for humility, and preached rising from it, while the fire fell around him. The line from the desert to Northampton to Azusa is not a line of frauds. It is a line of fire, and the only question the whole Church ever asked of fire is whether it stays on the altar.

Pentecostal fire without liturgical discipline has produced real chaos, and the hardest case stands above, a camp-meeting revelation in 1913 that nearly carried a movement off the Trinity itself, the unanchored prophecy doing precisely what Montanus did and what Paul's chapter exists to prevent. But cessationism carries its own warning label, for the doctrine was argued piecemeal since Calvin and hardened into a treatise only at Princeton, in the age that found rationalism respectable, so the free churchman may fairly ask whether the gifts ceased or the expectation did. The body remains divided on the question, and the honest position is the one the first millennium kept: possible, tested, ordered, and never made a dogma in either direction.

So the counsel to the Pentecostal is not to choose between the fire and the form, because the men who worked the wonders never chose. Watch how they behaved around the liturgy of the old communions: Antony under his bishop, Hildegard under obedience, Pio silent under discipline for years with the wounds still in his hands. The pattern already has modern heirs, for there are congregations that pray in tongues and keep the ancient rite in one service, a convergence the young movements keep discovering, and Rome herself has housed a charismatic renewal inside the order of the Mass for nearly sixty years. The fire does not need a stand-alone start-up church. It burned brightest, longest, in the churches with altars, where the Supper was weekly, the creed was said, and the prophets were subject to the prophets. Bind the frame, and the fire is free.

The churches not charted, and why

Parachurch is a word like non-denominational, and the plain thing under it is this: the mission agencies, the campus ministries, the Bible translators, and the relief armies are not churches. No altar, no ordained ministry, no membership at the water, and their own best charters say so,

existing to serve the churches. They are organizations, NGOs, and a Christian NGO is an honorable thing to be. The danger is only the substitute, the believer whose whole church is an organization, formed with no Baptism administered, no Supper spread, no orders, no discipline. So the ask is short. Say what you are. Serve as what you are. And hand the believers you win to churches taking up the whole faith.

The work claimed	Wycliffe	YWAM	Operation Mobilization	The Salvation Army
The gospel preached to the nations	✓	✓	✓	✓
The Scriptures translated and carried	✓	✓	✓	✓
The poor served in Christ's name	✓	✓	✓	✓
Believers gathered toward the local church	✓	✓	✓	?††
The claim to be a church	○	○	○	✓††
The sacraments and orders of the nine rows	○	○	○	✕††

†† The Salvation Army is the delicate column, and this page will say the kind thing plainly, which is not the soft thing. She is not a church. She is a parachurch organization that sincerely believes herself a church, and the judgment is not ours but the Creed's, for the binding faith of Nicaea confesses one baptism for the remission of sins, and a body that does not baptize at all is not missing a nicety, it is missing a mark the received faith makes essential. And said the other way, the reclassification is the mercy. Judged as a church she fails at the water. Seen as what she actually is, a servant organization of magnificent scale, she leads this chart, for no body on earth out-serves her among the poor, her holiness is famous, and her people who seek the water she does not forbid. But she is the tree's last lesson all the same. The thinning does not stop at believe and be baptized, for carried far enough it lets go even of the water, and a few generations past the last binding confession even Baptism itself proved losable, this whole page's warning gathered into one beloved and uniformed body. What a church does not bind it cannot keep. And the Commission's errand is larger than any one row, for make disciples of all nations continues, baptizing them, so the water she lacks shadows even the work she does best. She is welcome on this page's chart as what she is, the greatest of the servants, and the door back to being a church stands where it always stood, at the water.

The further the schisms run, the thinner the marks become, until at the parachurch the whole inheritance has narrowed to believe, be baptized, read your Bible. Some will say that is the essence at last, Christianity with everything inessential burned away. The first millennium did

not think so, for the burned-away things were the creed, the Supper, the ministry, and the whole worshipping shape of the faith. But there is a stranger and better possibility, and it is hiding in the parachurch's own name. Para means beside. An organization that stands beside the churches, bound to none of them and trusted across all of them, is built, whether it knows it or not, for the one errand no divided church can run: pressing the churches themselves back toward each other. The parachurch already brokers the moral alliances, already carries the Scriptures across every border, already treats the baptized of every column as one people. Let it say so out loud, and it becomes what the divided centuries never had, a servant of reunion with no see to defend. And if that work succeeded, the parachurch would be the one body on this page that could die happy, for the call of Jesus demands loyalty to no company, corporation, or nonprofit, but to the gospel and the one holy catholic and apostolic Church, and an organization founded to serve the churches can have no better end than to be no longer needed.

This page is not exhaustive. The Adventists, the Mennonites, and the Restorationists, among others, are noted at the foot of the page.

The mainline denominations are not columns here because they fell from part one's chart at the morals row, and the conservative columns of this chart are the engagement with their traditions. And the Oneness bodies are not columns because this chart's floor is Nicaea itself, the Oneness baptismal formula stands outside it, and the Assemblies' story above is the whole cautionary tale already told, for the Statement of 1916 was written precisely to hold that door.

There is no such thing as a non-denominational church. A fellowship with its own statement of faith, its own association of churches, its own conferences, its own music, its own recognizable order of worship, and its own way of ordaining is a denomination, and the prefix only means it declines to say so. The people inside are often among the most sincere believers in America, and the label is the one untrue thing about them. Naming it costs nothing and buys everything, for a church that admits it is a church can ask what its foundations are, and that question is this page.

Part IV. The chart, and the asks

Charting the free churches

The Reformed family stands charted above. The remaining churches are charted here, by the same rows.

✓ confessed in the communion's binding standards.

? substance affirmed while mode or formula stands open, or the question itself not yet closed.

✗ not confessed in the standards as they stand, and nothing more. The mark reverses its meaning across the chart, as in part one: among the received rows a red X marks a gap, among the bound-alone rows it marks only what that church never bound, which is no fault at all. No mark on this chart puts anyone out of the Body of Christ, and the notes carry the argument the glyphs cannot.

○ nothing is bound on this article at all, and the circle records the fact, neither credit nor fault, only the absence this page is about.

The chart measures standards, not Christians. Every column baptizes into the one Body, and every red X among the received rows is healable by the hand that set it. Each column's case follows the chart.

	The faith confessed	Southern Baptist	Global Methodist	Assemblies of God	Non-denominational
RECEIVED BY THE WHOLE CHURCH IN THE FIRST MILLENNIUM					
Catholicity together	The Holy Scriptures	✓	✓	✓	✓
	The Nicene Creed	✓§	✓	✓	✓
	The christology of the seven councils	✓	✓	✓	✓
	Mary the Theotokos, Mother of God (Ephesus) ¶	?	?	?	?
	The veneration of the holy icons (Nicaea II)	○***	✗***	○***	○***
	The apostolic succession of bishops	?*	?†	?*	○
	The real presence in the Eucharist (corporeal)	✗**	?**	✗**	✗**
	The regeneration given in Baptism	✗§§	?§§	✗§§	✗§§
	The moral consensus of the Fathers (life, marriage, holy orders) ‡	✓	✓	✓	✓
BOUND BY ONE CHURCH ALONE, AND SO NOT RECEIVED BY THE WHOLE					

	The faith confessed	Southern Baptist	Global Methodist	Assemblies of God	Non-denominational
<i>Set down, not thrown away, awaiting reception</i>	The Baptist Faith and Message as binding (2000)	✓	✗	✗	✗
	The Methodist Articles and Discipline as binding (1784)	✗	✓	✗	✗
	The Statement of Fundamental Truths as binding (1916)	✗	✗	✓	✗
	Any confession binding the whole church	✓	✓	✓	○

§ What counts in this row is the faith itself, not the wording, for the Church has always received the faith before the formula, which is how the ancient churches of Egypt and the East kept the whole faith for centuries without signing the other side's words. The Creed's own text is another matter, and the Southern Baptist Convention has been debating it on its own floor, motions at Indianapolis in 2024, at Dallas in 2025, and at Orlando in 2026, where two were sent on for a year of study, a communion weighing the walk from the substance toward the symbol in Nicaea's anniversary years.

¶ Every column already believes what the title Theotokos guards, that the child Mary bore is true God. What none of them does is say the ancient word, and that is why the question marks stand where checks could one day be.

* Ordered ministries exist in every column, ordination by the laying on of hands of elders, councils, credentialing, superintendents. Whether presbyteral succession preserves the ministry is the question the bishop and presbyter paper leaves open, and no more than that open question is claimed here.

† The crown cell of this chart. The Global Methodist bishops descend from Wesley's ordinations of 1784, a presbyter of the Church of England ordaining superintendents for America, and Wesley refused the word bishop to the end, rebuking Asbury for taking it. Methodism is the largest living experiment in presbyteral succession, the bishop and presbyter paper's question walking around in history at denominational scale.

** The Methodist cell carries the question mark on the same grounds as part one's Presbyterian cell, for Article XVIII confesses the body given, taken, and eaten, only after an heavenly and spiritual manner, reception affirmed and the mode refused, the same divided answer, and the counterweight leans harder here than Calvin leans on Westminster, for the standard's own founders sang it: the eucharistic hymns of the Wesleys confess as high a Supper as Protestant England ever sang. The Baptist and Pentecostal

standards speak of ordinance and symbol, and the X records it. The deeper argument, Calvin, the Mercersburg school, and the open mark, lives in part one's presence note and reaches every mark in this row.

§§ The credobaptist standards refuse both the infant and the instrument, baptism an ordinance of obedience testifying to a grace already given. The Methodist Article keeps sign language while Wesley's own Treatise on Baptism taught the washing of regeneration, which is why the Methodist cell bears a question mark. The ancient evidence is set down in two receipts and no more. Origen calls the baptism of little children a tradition received from the apostles, and Cyprian's council of sixty-six bishops in 253 debated not whether an infant should be baptized but whether he must wait eight days, while Tertullian's lone advice to delay is itself proof the practice was old enough to argue with.

*** The circle beside the X is this row's whole lesson. The Methodist Articles keep the old Anglican censure, and the X records it. The Southern Baptist, Assemblies, and non-denominational standards say nothing at all, which is not tolerance but silence, and the difference between a church that refuses the image and a church that has never asked the question is the difference this page exists to name.

‡ Green across, and it is why these columns are the columns. Every communion on this chart is a conservative body whose mainline counterpart fell at this row, and their standing has already done quiet work, for holding the moral line side by side has taught believers across all these divides to recognize one another as brothers.

○ Read the bound-alone rows downward and the finding draws itself. Each younger church bound less, until the newest binds nothing, and a church that binds nothing cannot drift from its confession, for it has nowhere to drift from and nothing to drift back to. For the confessional columns the ask is Augsburg's, hold the standard as patrimony rather than exact it. For the last column there is nothing yet to hold, which is why the ask of that church is not to set down but to pick up.

The non-denominational cells are read from the prevailing statements of faith, which nearly all confess the checked rows and speak of the Supper and Baptism as ordinance and symbol, which the red X marks record. The circle in the last row records the deeper fact, that no single statement binds the fellowship as a communion, each congregation adopting its own.

What catholicity asks of the young churches

The Southern Baptist case. Two steps are local and can happen this year. His convention's own preamble says confessions are guides with no authority over the conscience, and his congregation is autonomous, so his church can adopt the Nicene Creed into its own statement and say it on Sunday, as some already have. The Supper's frequency is likewise his congregation's call, and weekly is an elder decision. The third step is the floor: the Baptist Faith and Message amends by messenger vote, two thirds at two consecutive meetings, the Nicene motions of 2024 through 2026 sit under Executive Committee study, and his church sends messengers every June, so send them instructed. After the creed, the same process can weigh the Supper's symbolic-act article against Paul's own participation, and the water against Origen and Cyprian. That is how catholicity is held in a Southern Baptist congregation, half this year by local vote, half in Junes to come.

The Global Methodist case. Read all of his standards, for they are wider than his Articles. The Discipline holds Wesley's Standard Sermons and Notes as doctrine beside the Articles, Wesley's sermon on constant communion commands a frequency the Article never addresses, and the Wesleys' eucharistic hymns confess a height the Article's manner language has been read to flatten, so the weekly Supper at full strength is a matter of reading his own doctrine, not fighting it. The same at the water: the Article keeps sign language, the founder taught the washing of regeneration. On the ministry, his bishops descend from a presbyter's hands, the question the bishop and presbyter paper weighs, and the standing Anglican and Methodist dialogues on the healing of orders are the road, a young General Conference freer to walk it than any old one. On the icons, amend Article XIV, a censure his founders copied rather than chose. That is how catholicity is held in the Methodist communion, by reading Wesley whole, and Wesley whole points backward.

The Pentecostal case. His fellowship wrote a binding creed within two years of its founding, because the New Issue of 1913 to 1916 was losing the Trinity, and the General Council that wrote and amends that Statement can adopt the older creed it already paraphrases: confess Nicaea, for nothing in his standards forbids it. Second, read his own founding text whole, Acts 2:38, baptism, remission, and the Spirit bound in one breath, the ancient reading of the water waiting inside it. Third, spread the Supper weekly, his congregation's own schedule, an elder decision. His ministry is already ordered, districts, credentials, a General Superintendent, and waits only on the question of its order, which the bishop and presbyter paper leaves open. That is how catholicity is held in a Pentecostal fellowship, by keeping the creed his fathers were forced to write, saying the one their fathers wrote, and letting the fervor fill the shape.

The non-denominational case. His congregation is governed by its own elders, so three steps need nobody's permission. Write the Nicene Creed into the statement of faith and say it on Sunday. Spread the Supper weekly, as the Restorationists have done for two centuries. Teach the creed to every baptismal candidate, the use the ancient church built it for. The fourth step is the honest one: an ordered ministry cannot be self-supplied, for ordination is received from hands that received it, and a congregation cannot lay hands on itself, so the fourth step is joining something, binding standards, a communion of churches, and the congregation that takes all four steps has stopped being non-denominational. That is not defeat, it is the destination, walked now one congregation at a time. That is how catholicity is held in a non-denominational congregation, briefly, on the way to holding it somewhere with a name.

Part V. The objection, and the end of the matter

The private judgment objection

Rome has watched this whole tree grow, and her objection deserves its full strength: all of it, she will say, is private judgment's harvest. Leave the magisterium and the one-man independent church follows, for once every man is his own interpreter, division has no floor, and the bottom of the tree is simply the top of the tree ripened. The charge is serious, the tree looks like its exhibit, and half of this page has agreed with half of it.

But the objection proves too much and too little at once. The Orthodox have rejected the papal claims for a thousand years, and they are not down at the bottom of the tree. Their sister churches quarrel and even break communion for seasons, but the family neither multiplies without limit nor thins its inheritance, and after ten centuries without a pope the Divine Liturgy is what it was. The Anglicans, the confessional Lutherans, and the high Presbyterian line have rejected the same claims for five centuries, and they divided, as this site's charts show in the open, but the tree did not grow straight down from them. Their divisions, real as these charts record them, hold creeds, courts, and rites, and multiply at nothing like the pace of the tree's floor. If private judgment alone grew the tree, the East and the confessional bodies would be in its roots with everyone else. They are not, so private judgment is not the whole story, and the objection begs the question it was built to settle.

And the unity Rome offers as the alternative is, on the ground, paper. The book concedes the old Protestant critique in as many words, for within the one canonical communion stand believers who deny each other the name of Christian, parishes that will not imitate each other's worship, and orders that once prayed as one and now would not recognize each other's theology, all in full communion with the pope and all calling each other heretics, the schisms real and simply undeclared. Nor does the system spare her sons the judging, for the man inside must still choose which parish, which catechism, which century of papal teaching to weight, and the choosing is private judgment wearing a cassock. Scripture's own reader, asked whether he understood what he read, gave Scripture's own answer, how can I, except some man should guide me, and the Church has been the someone ever since. And the rest of the standard objections, all fifty of them, are answered one by one on their own page. The thorough case is the book's, the reversals of Rome set side by side in its fourth section and weighed act by act in its appendices, while the About page walks the Roman Catholic through the wreckage with sanity, and even Rome's opponents keep a straight ledger.

So if not private judgment, what is the difference maker? Every man on it judges, the Roman included, so judgment is the constant and cannot be the cause. What varies is what judgment is submitted to. Where a man's judgment answers to a received standard, held by an ordered body, rehearsed in a rite, the creed, the court, and the liturgy, division has a floor under it. Where nothing binds, division has no floor, and the tree grows straight down. And the two extremes secretly agree, for the independent church makes one man's reading final, and the maximal papacy makes one man's definition final, of himself and not from the consent of the Church, which is the same error wearing different clothes, private judgment enthroned rather than cured. The cure at both ends is one cure, the book's whole proposal: judgment exercised inside the received consensus of the whole, tested in council, guarded by creed and rite, and submitted to reception. The key is not fewer judges. It is a bound inheritance and a Body to answer to, which is why this page asks the young churches, the Baptist and the Pentecostal and their cousins, to bind, and part one asks the older communions to unbind only what the whole never received. Both asks aim judgment at the same home, the whole Church.

What all of it means

The free churches are real churches full of real Christians, baptized believers with faith in Jesus, holding in general the basic tenets of the Nicene Creed to the best of their understanding. Measured, they are missing things, not because their people are lesser but because their history threw the inheritance overboard a piece at a time to keep the ship light, and the pages above walked every piece to the rail: the creed in one generation, the bishops in another, the Supper's weekly gift, the grace of the water, until the newest churches sail fast and carry almost nothing. But every missing piece still exists. None of it needs inventing. The creed is still said, the Supper is still spread, the ministry is still ordered, in the churches these churches came from, and this page has told no one where to drive on Sunday. What it asks is the oldest motion in the Church's story, reception: see what the whole Church

has always carried, and reach for it. The older communions are asked to lay down what only they carry. The free churches are asked to pick up what everyone once carried. And if both motions keep moving, they meet, and the meeting has a name: one holy catholic and apostolic Church.

And the proof that none of this is foreign is already in the pew rack. Let All Mortal Flesh Keep Silence is the Liturgy of Saint James, the ancient Eucharist sung in evangelical churches that would never say the word liturgy. Of the Father's Love Begotten is Prudentius, a Roman lawyer turned poet born in the fourth century, and every December the same congregations sing round yon virgin mother and child, the Theotokos confessed in a carol. The free churches have been singing catholicity all along. This page has only asked them to mean it on purpose.

You may be the only person in your congregation who has come this far, the only one who wants the creed said or the Supper spread, and nothing above gave you a committee to join. Good. The book's whole account of change is that nothing moves by decree and everything moves by confession, one believer at a time, across more years than one life holds. So say the creed at home until you can say it in company. Keep the old fasts quietly. Pray for your pastor instead of cornering him, ask for the Supper more often and mean it, and be unsurprised if you are early, for reception has always looked like this at the start, one confessor, then two. This page asked your church to pick things up. Someone has to be the first to reach.

The older communions, Rome and the Orthodox and the confessional churches, are asked to set down what the whole Church never received, and the free churches are asked to bind what the whole Church always did, the creed already believed, bound, the Supper already received, received as the gift it is, the ministry already answered, ordered. Both motions walk toward the same nine rows from opposite sides, which is why the same nine rows can measure every column of both pages, and one prayer can close them: that they all may be one, that the world may believe (John 17:21).

Back to part one: the historic communions · Continue to part three: the fifty objections.

A note on churches not charted above.

The Seventh-day Adventists are the largest church family this page does not chart, some twenty million strong, and they are owed the honest sentence rather than silence. They are the heirs of the Millerite midnight of 1844, the one failed date in the timetable ledger that built a denomination instead of a repentance, and their standards are Trinitarian today, their health work is famous, and their missionaries circle the earth. But their sabbath sets them against the Lord's Day the whole Church has kept since the apostles, their investigative judgment is a doctrine bound by one church alone and received by no one else, and a communion founded on a date's failure carries the timetable problem in its founding stone. They are owed a fuller word than this page can give.

The Mennonites and the Anabaptist line are a Reformation stream of their own, older than the English Baptists and not their ancestor, pacifist, plain, and morally serious, and they too are owed a fuller word than this footnote gives.

The Restorationists, the Churches of Christ and the Christian Churches of the Stone-Campbell line, are owed a column in a future revision, for no free church family would chart more strangely or more hopefully. Their founding instinct was this page's own instinct, the restoration of the primitive church, and they took up two things almost nobody else did: the Supper every Sunday, which almost no other free church kept, and baptism for the remission of sins in the words of Acts 2:38, the nearest thing to the ancient grace of Baptism confessed anywhere on this page. They baptize in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, and stand above this chart's floor. But the founder's own story carries the warning the family has never bound: Barton Stone, creedless on principle, wandered on the Trinity itself, and the movement's answer was practice without confession, the triune formula kept at the water while no creed guarded the teaching. So their path to catholicity is the sanest on the page, because it is only their own instinct finished. Keep the weekly Supper. Keep the baptism for remission. And let the primitive church they seek be the one in the documents, the church of Justin and the Didache, which kept a creed at the water precisely so that what happened to Stone could not happen to the flock.

Quod ubique, quod semper, quod ab omnibus.

Scripture quotations are from the King James Version unless otherwise noted.